

## Syria



**An Arab one-party state that has had turbulent foreign relations since independence in 1941.**

**600s BCE** Area part of Assyrian Empire.

**1st century BCE** Area part of Roman Empire.

**634 CE** Muslim forces conquer Syria, defeating the Byzantines.

**997 CE** Northern Syria falls to the Byzantines and the south is ruled by the Egyptian Fatimid dynasty.

**1098** Antioch captured by crusaders.

**1260–1516** The Mamluks control Syria.

**1516** Syria falls to the Ottomans.

**1918** Arab troops led by Emir Faisal enter Damascus after 400 years of Ottoman rule.

**1920** Faisal proclaimed king. After San Remo Conference awards Syria to France, he is ousted by French forces who proclaim new state of Greater Lebanon.

**1925–26** Uprising against French rule.

**1941** British and French occupy Syria and promise end to the French mandate.

**1958–61** Syria united with Egypt in the United Arab Republic.

**1963** Ba'athist military junta seizes power. Major General Amin al-Hafez becomes president.

**1966** Hafez ousted by military coup supported by radical Ba'ath Party members.

**1967** Israel overruns Syrian positions above Lake Tiberias, seizes Golan Heights, and occupies Quneitra.

**1970** Hafez al-Assad seizes power.

**1973** New constitution secures Ba'ath Party dominance. More territory temporarily lost to Israel in war.

**1976** With a peacekeeping mandate from Arab League, Syria intervenes to quell fighting in Lebanon.

**1977** Relations broken off with Egypt after President Sadat's visit to Jerusalem.

**1978** Assad returned for second term.

**1980** Membership in extremist Muslim Brotherhood made capital offense.

**1981** Israel annexes Golan Heights.

**1982** Islamic extremist uprising in Hama crushed; thousands killed. Israel invades Lebanon; Syrian missiles in Bekaa Valley are destroyed.

**1985** Assad reelected president.

**1986** Syrian complicity alleged in planting a bomb on Israeli airliner in London.

**1989** Diplomatic relations reestablished with Egypt.

**1991** Syrian troops take part in US-led invasion of Kuwait. The Damascus Declaration, an aid and defense pact with Egypt, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, and Oman, is signed.

**1999** Assad reconfirmed as president.

**2000** Death of Hafez al-Assad. He is succeeded by his son Bashar.

**2001** Syrian troops leave Beirut.

**2003** Israel bombs "terrorist camps" in Syria.

**2006** Thousands flee into Syria to escape Israel's attack on Lebanon.

**2006** Iraq and Syria restore diplomatic relations after a break of nearly 25 years (but they are broken off again in 2009–10).

**2009** Syrian stock exchange starts trading.

**2010** US restores sanctions against Syria, accusing it of supporting terrorist groups such as Hezbollah.

«54–55 The Cradle of Civilization

«80–81 Rulers of the Iron Age

## Lebanon



**Once a refuge for persecuted religious and political groups, Lebanon was shattered by civil war.**

**600s BCE** Area part of Assyrian Empire.

**1st century BCE** The area becomes part of the Roman Empire.

**900s** Muslim sects begin their penetration of the Lebanese mountains.

**1516–17** The Ottomans conquer Lebanon.

**1633** Ottoman Sultan Murad IV takes control of Lebanon.

**1860** The Druzes and Maronites clash and massacres are carried out by both sides.

**1920** France creates Greater Lebanon, which includes Tripoli, Tyre, and Beirut.

**1941** The Free French proclaim Lebanon independent. Full autonomy comes in 1946 when last French troops withdraw.

**1958** President Kamil Shamoun requests the presence of US troops.

**1975** Civil war erupts between Christian and Muslim militias.

**1978** Israel invades and occupies territory. Israel invades again in 1982.

**1983** More than 300 US and French troops are killed by two bombs in Beirut planted by militant Shia groups.

**1989** Taif Agreement ends civil war.

**1991** Militias are disbanded but radical Islamist group Hezbollah and Christian South Lebanon Army (SLA) do not comply.

**1992** First election in 20 years. Rafiq al-Hariri prime minister.

**1996** Israeli attack kills over 100 civilians at the UN base in Qana.

**1998** Émile Lahoud becomes president.

**2000** Israeli forces withdraw from southern Lebanon.

**2005** Former prime minister Rafik Hariri is killed by a car bomb. Calls for Syria to withdraw its troops intensify.

**2006** Israel launches strikes against Lebanon after Hezbollah captures two Israeli soldiers. Truce declared after 34 days of war.

**2007** Lebanese army lays siege to a Palestinian refugee camp for four months. More than 300 die.

**2008** A new cabinet is formed by Prime Minister Fouad Siniora; Hezbollah ministers have enough posts to afford them a veto.

**2009** The International tribunal set up to try suspected killers of assassinated PM

Hariri opens in the Hague. Pro-Western party led by Saad Hariri wins most seats in general election.

«80–81 Rulers of the Iron Age

«414–15 The Promised Land

## Jordan



**An independent kingdom since 1946, most of whose people live along the east bank of the Jordan River.**

**1918** King Faisal establishes autonomous Arab government in Damascus.

**1920** The Palestine mandate, covering present-day Israel, Jordan, and the West Bank, is awarded to the UK. King Faisal is forced out of Damascus.

**1921** Hashemite King Abdullah is proclaimed ruler of Transjordan.

**1948** State of Israel created in British-mandate Palestine. Thousands of Palestinians flee Arab–Israeli fighting to the West Bank and Jordan.

**1949** The remainder of Palestine becomes the "Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan."

**1950** Jordan annexes the West Bank and East Jerusalem.

**1953** Hussein is proclaimed king after the assassination of his uncle Abdullah.

**1967** Israel seizes West Bank territories during the Six-Day War.

**1970** A massive crackdown on the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) results in thousands of casualties in a civil war known as Black September.

**1986** King Hussein breaks all political links with the PLO.

**1988** Jordan cedes claims to the West Bank to the PLO. Hussein publicly backs the Palestinian uprising, or intifada, against Israeli rule.

**1989** First general election held since 1967 but contested only by independent candidates as political parties are banned.

**1990** Severe economic and diplomatic strain affects country—a result of Iraq's invasion of Kuwait.

**1994** Peace treaty with Israel ends a 46-year state of war.

**1999** King Hussein dies and is succeeded by King Abdullah II.

**2002** Agreement with Israel to pipe water from the Red Sea to the shrinking Dead Sea. The project is the two countries' largest joint venture.

**2005** Explosions kill 56 people, mostly Jordanians, at three hotels in Amman. Al-Qaeda in Iraq claims responsibility.



French fortress

The crusader castle Krak des Chevaliers, built in the 12th century, was the power center of the French Knights Hospitaller in the Holy Land and one of the greatest crusader fortresses of medieval Christendom. It eventually fell to the Arab leader Baibars after a short siege in 1271.